MISS PELL'S CASE OF THE WEEK · NO. 4

# By the Bonfire

*In 1931, every Friday at seven o'clock, the gates of Ashcombe Manor were locked and Lord Ashcombe's guests played a game. His secretary, Miss Pell, dealt each guest a card in silence: one said victim, one said murderer. The lamps went out for one minute. When they came back on, nobody was allowed to move, and Miss Pell went from room to room with her notebook.*

## HOW TO PLAY

1. **Every statement is true.** Read each one against the plan.
2. **Exactly one suspect stands in every row and every column.** The body is not a suspect. Areas have no such rule: an area may hold several suspects, or none.
3. **The murderer is the one suspect in the area with the body.** That area always holds exactly one suspect, and the rule works while you solve: once one suspect must be there, nobody else can be.

Rows are numbered from the top and columns from the left, so R2C5 is the second row, fifth column; north is the top of the plan. Hatched squares are where nobody can stand. A dark outline around a whole square means nobody can see past it, like a wall. Write initials on the plan as you go: small where a suspect *might* be, large where they *must* be. There is exactly one answer, and you never need to guess.

**In the Hall, at the Lake, on the Green:** anywhere in that area.

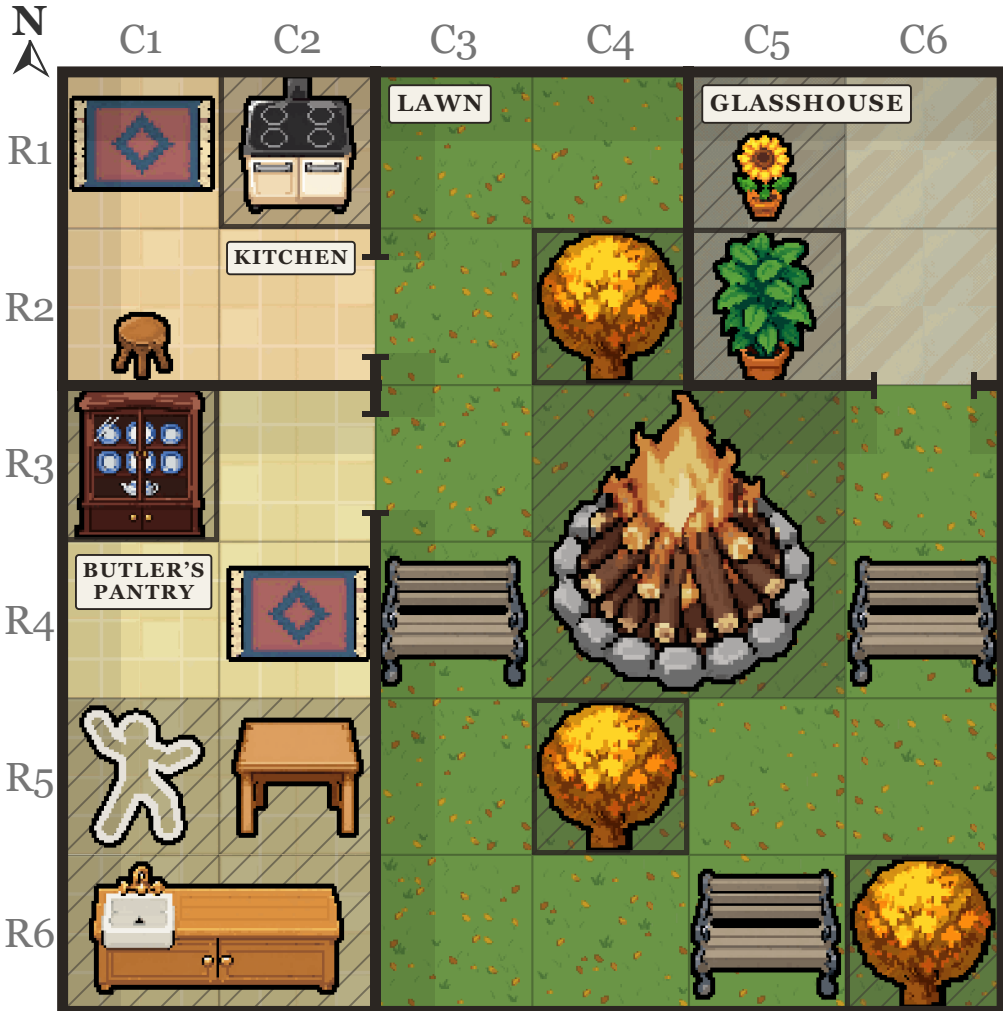
**Beside:** in a square next to it, up, down, left or right, and in the same area. Never diagonally, and never through a wall or a doorway. Sitting or standing on something, a chair or a rug, is not being beside it, but another one next to your square is.

**Could see:** straight along a row or a column, through doorways, until a wall or an outlined piece stops the view; you see that piece, but nothing behind it. Never diagonally, and people never block the view. The square you stand on does not count.

**Two rows north and one column east:** an exact distance, counted in squares.

**North of, west of:** compares rows or columns, and nothing else. North is the top of the plan, east is the right.

**Wore, had:** what the lineup shows under each suspect's picture. *Everyone beside a clock, if anyone, had a beard* does not say that anyone stood beside one.




*The first Friday of November, and the bonfire was still burning. When the lamps came back on, Walter lay in the Butler's Pantry.*

THE CLUES

1. Martin was two rows north and one column east of Violet.
2. Bernard could see the bonfire.
3. Frank shared an area with someone who was beside the bonfire.
4. Robin was north of Grace.
5. Grace was not beside a table.
6. Violet was on the Lawn.

GENERAL CLUES

7. Everyone beside the bonfire, if anyone, wore a bowler.

THE SUSPECTS



1. Martin
a fedora
a beard



2. Bernard
spectacles
a beard



3. Frank
spectacles
a beard



4. Grace
a bowler
a monocle



5. Robin
a fedora
spectacles
a beard

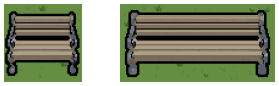


6. Violet
a bowler
spectacles

THE MURDERER _____

# The Furniture

Every piece in this case, drawn as on the plan, and the two things that matter about each: whether a suspect can stand on its square, and whether a suspect can see past it.



bench

✓ can sit or stand here
✓ can see past it



bonfire

✗ nobody can stand here
✓ can see past it



china cabinet

✗ nobody can stand here
✗ blocks the view



potted plant

✗ nobody can stand here
✗ blocks the view



rug

✓ can sit or stand here
✓ can see past it



sink

✗ nobody can stand here
✓ can see past it



stool

✓ can sit or stand here
✓ can see past it



stove

✗ nobody can stand here
✗ blocks the view



sunflower

✗ nobody can stand here
✓ can see past it



table

✗ nobody can stand here
✓ can see past it



tree

✗ nobody can stand here
✗ blocks the view

# Stuck?

Three hints, each giving away a little more than the last. Read one, then go back to the plan.

**Hint I · Where to begin.** Start with Martin. Clues 1, 6 and 7 together leave him exactly one square. Clue 7 names nobody, but it applies to him too: find him in the lineup.

**Hint II · When you are stuck.** Read clues 2 and 7 together: they are enough to place the next suspect. Don’t set clue 7 aside: it is true of everyone, and can do its work more than once. Clue 2 is about what Bernard could see. From each square still open to him, look along the row and the column, never diagonally, through doorways, up to a wall or onto an outlined piece. By this point two suspects should be placed.

**Hint III · A checkpoint.** Martin at R1C4, Violet at R3C3, Bernard at R6C5.

# Who did it?

The answer, step by step, is at whereaboutspuzzles.com on Saturday.

## Fifty more cases

Miss Pell wrote every game into a ledger: a whole year of Fridays at Ashcombe Manor, from the first daffodils to the last of the snow. **Whereabouts: Murder Sudoku — 50 Murder Mysteries from Ashcombe Manor** is that ledger, with a practice case solved for you, three levels of hints for every case, and the answers step by step.

And every Friday, a new case is free at **whereaboutspuzzles.com**.

A free case from *Whereabouts*. © 2026 Victor Knox. Print it for yourself, your family and your friends as often as you like; please don't sell it or post it elsewhere. The puzzles come from our own generator, which checks that every case has exactly one answer and can be solved by deduction alone. Illustrations generated with PixelLab, then retouched to a single house style and composed into each floor plan by the author.